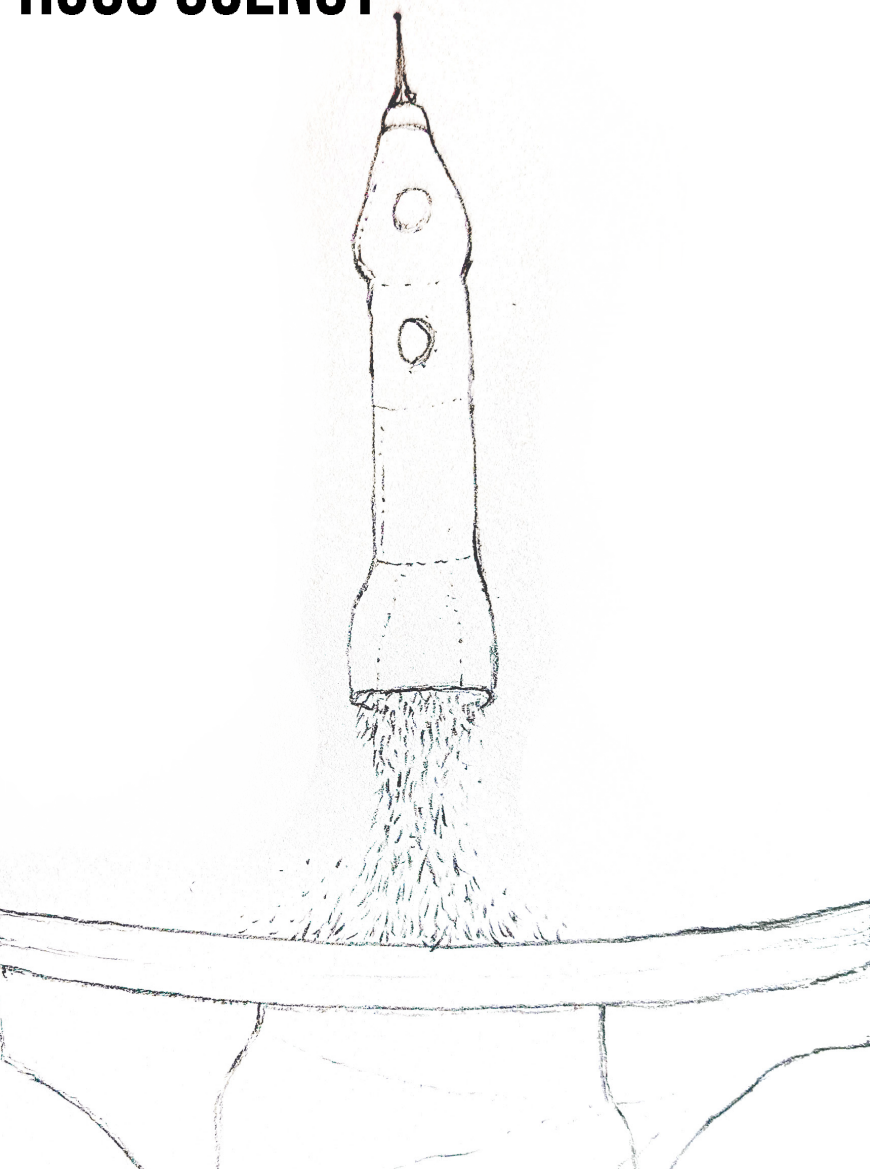


STARCRUISER HUGO CUENOT



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Cruiz stands up from his chair, throws away his empty coffee cup in the trash, then leaves the cold coffee place. He has been waiting all day for a message, but nothing has come so far. The coffee place is right across the street from his place. It's early morning, traffic is still light, he crosses the avenue and walks towards his building entrance. He has been waiting for an important mail, waiting to see the delivery car turn at the corner all morning, but nothing so far. The restlessness that took him to the coffee place across the street takes him back to his place.

His front door opens as he approaches, letting him inside his apartment in a swooshing noise. He drops his large coat on the floor and sends his boots flying, leaving mud streaks on the floor. He goes to stand by the large window overlooking the street. There, he stands, head on the glass, lighting up a cigarette. Below him in the street, busy people go on with their lives, fighting the wind pushing in their legs. He

stares out blankly.

He inhales deeply on his cigarette, holds the smoke for a second, then slowly releases the smoke towards his bed, lingering above it for a moment, then slowly dissipates. He thinks about his friend Zamil, he's been waiting for him to come back from his mission, but the silence is deafening. He hasn't received any news in a while, but he had received a notification from the postal service that an important message was on its way about him and is expected to arrive today. He couldn't imagine what this was about, and was hoping for good news at least. The nature of their relationship was still unclear to most, even to each other. They are very close friends, keeping their relationship platonic so far, but their strong bond is undeniable. That made his disappearance without a word or a trace all the more brutal and suspicious. He had gone to a remote station to work for this company, Phallacy.

A gigantic consortium whose activity goes from simple retail to asteroid mining, as well as large scale armament industry. Zamil hadn't told him where or what he was going to do for them, his contract was designed behind a well-protected, heavily legislated system that prevented him from talking about it to anyone. He couldn't

think of anything dangerous that he could have been asked to do, Zamil being a kind of administrator rat. He should have come back two weeks ago, but delays aren't uncommon. Receiving a notification from the postal service however is. His cigarette now a pile of ashes at his feet, he takes another one out, plays with it between his fingers, still staring out the window. He's lighting his cigarette, staring at the reddening end when in the corner of his eye, he notices the postal truck a block away from his apartment building. He lets the cigarette fall and carelessly crushes it with his foot before rushing at the door. He runs down the stairs, in too much of a hurry to wait for the elevator. When he reaches the mailboxes, the mail has already been distributed. He opens the mailbox to his name, and in it, a white envelope with black edges. He takes it out slowly, his heart beating fast in his chest. He tears it open carefully, taking the light white paper out of it.

The letter also has black edges all around. It is addressed to him, coming from Phallacy. He tries to read it slowly, but his eyes keep jumping to the next line, trying to take in the content as fast as possible. His heart drops when finally, he understands what the letter is about. Like he suspected, something happened to Zamil. Rea-

ding through the corporate jargon, he understands that something unexpected happened to him, leading to a sudden and mysterious disappearance that even the authorities there couldn't figure out.

Given the extreme nature of the mission he was given, they have to legally report it as a fatal disappearance, but that they will keep doing everything in their power to keep looking for him. He reads it again, looking for something written between the lines. The short feeling of relief is hardening in his gut, morphing into silent anger. He takes the stairs back up, slowly, the paper still locked in his grip. His mind is going fast, thinking of what to do next, planning with each step he takes. By the time he reaches his floor he has the outline of a plan in mind to go after Zamil and take the matter into his own hands, knowing full well the extent of the incompetence of the authorities, even more so when a big company is involved. There clearly is something fishy in this, and he intends to uncover it.

He is back in his apartment, straightening the mess he had left behind. He needs a clear space

to think about how to get to the station where Zamil was posted. The plan is simple: get to the station, start to investigate, find what happened to his friend then go home, hopefully with him. The hard part is to get there. He could try to take a shuttle and approach them on his own, but this is a high security station, alone, he has no chance. So, he could get there sneakily with the help of a smuggler, but once again, too many blind spots, too many weaknesses in this plan. The more he is thinking about it, the more evident it becomes that he is going to have to get hired by Phallacy at the same station as his friend, and do the investigation from within, as an employee. He sits down heavily on the couch, head thrown back, staring at the smooth ceiling, smells of the city coming through the opened window. Time to set the plan in motion and look up the job offers they have on the station. Phallacy has a total of eleven stations spanning across millions of kilometers in the system, such as research, mining, crops and even headquarters. Because international law does not apply the same way outside the atmosphere, it is very profitable to do tax evasion in outer space. Zamil was working in a scientific one, doing research on a sensitive subject. That leaves the only scientific station they have, Polari Station.

They have a total of seven open positions. The descriptions are vague, the job title cryptic. However, one of them is titled “Custodian”, no description attached to it. Maybe it sounds ludicrous, but that would be an ideal position to fulfill, at the center of everything, invisible and that didn’t require lying too much to get it. But he is going to need to contact some friends to help him create an alter ego, a fake identity to infiltrate without them making a connection between him and Zamil. The plan is set in motion. He decides right then and there to pay a visit to one of his most tech-savvy friends living in town to help him out make a rock-solid fake identity. He packs a light bag with few articles of clothing, a vanity with some essentials, as well as a handful of hardware tools, just in case. He grabs his coat and just like that, he’s on his way.

Cruiz is sitting in a shuttle on its way to the Polari Station, along with five other people with whom he hadn't introduced himself while waiting on the launchpad. The reactors were making a loud noise until it died out once they left the atmosphere, the shuttle becoming silent, the air no longer rubbing against the fuselage, the burning fuel entirely consumed, the craft now cruising in the void to the secret scientific station.

Getting the job has been simpler than he had imagined. He went to see his friend Mary who helped him getting a new identity off the dark market and together they had made a rock-solid file for his alias. And like a fly to honey, Phallacy had been drawn to him and fell into his perfectly executed trap. He loves that he is using the idea that large companies like these don't care about their employees to his advantage. Because to them he is nothing more than a number in their file bank, they would never go to extreme lengths to check the legitimacy of a simple custodian, even for a highly secretive research lab. People around him are removing their seatbelts, floating around to look at the view through the portholes, their feet dangling, useless. Most were probably scientists. He remains

seated, extending his neck to take a peek outside, seeing a piece of blue in the distance floating in an ocean of black. Everything went very fast from the moment he applied for the job. He hadn't talked to the company yet, everything happened remotely, automatically, automatized. He only spoke to bots, giving him all the information he needed to be here now. This has been almost too easy so far. He only has a backpack full of clothes; he couldn't get on board with the tools he had taken from his place, but he did manage to bring in his notebook.

Outside, the planet is getting smaller, invisible after a few hours. Screens play videos on loop where perfect people smile, wearing the company's logo on their sweatshirt, advertising the good deeds and great culture of Phallacy but always remaining vague enough that it becomes impossible to know what exactly they're trying to sell you. It could have been dictatorship propaganda for all he knows, selling you a perfect idea, or an idea of perfection.

The journey is smooth sailing, he is getting used to the floating and pushing against every surface to move around the shuttle. Once they start getting close to the station, the crew asks them to buckle back down for safety. Everyone goes back to their seat, and stares at the station co-

ming in closer. It's a large building-like structure, floating in space. It is more angular than he thought it would be, and a lot of windows cover the outer shell.

It is much bigger that he had imagined, and for the moment, he can only see one face of the building, only glimpsing the extending building behind, sprawling appendages as big as the one in front of them. It starts to make sense how one person could disappear in there and how difficult it can be to try and look for them. As the windows he saw in the distance got closer, the scale reveals itself to him. One window must have been hundreds of meters tall, and as wide. They extend all the way across the façade, tens of them going in every direction. This is the largest building he has ever seen. It takes almost an hour for them to get really close to it from the moment it enters their field of view. A large door opens in the smooth grey surface of the building, swallowing the shuttle in darkness.

Lights turn on along a landing dock and the shuttle's thrusters throw large shadows everywhere. The landing is a bit rocky, everything is vibrating around them, it feels like the craft is going to rip in half. He starts to feel heavy as they get closer to the ground, his body gaining its weight back. It lands on the pad in a thud-

ding noise, a cloud of smoke rising around it.

Now he can feel his full weight in his arms and legs, almost like a relief. It takes a while for everyone getting used to their movements again and then to get down, led by the two pilots going down the ladder. The dock they landed on is an extremely large room, only lit around the landing area, and a narrow path towards an opening in the wall. The ceiling is so high he cannot see where it reaches, the echo dying out in the distance.

They follow the pilots towards the dark opening in the wall. The walls inside are the same grey as the outer walls of the station, Cruiz runs his hand along one to feel it. It is a sort of composite wall, between metal and concrete, cold and solid. They arrive in a small, carpeted room, with empty seats and counters and the pilots tell them to wait here for someone to come to us while they exit through a security door on the left.

A man comes in and welcomes them with a frozen corporate smile, his shiny hair combed back, reflecting the overhead light. Two other men trail behind him, notepads in hand, staring

blankly at the group. The small man asks them if the journey has been good for them, all the while the other two men take care of checking the paperwork of each person.

Cruiz's fake paper gets him through the security without any problems. He is asked to follow one of the men holding a notepad to another part of the complex while the others follow the other man. The young man he is following tells him that he is showing him to his quarters. They walk along grey carpeted corridors, passing empty rooms and closed doors until they reach a large hall resembling the landing site they were at earlier, simply smaller and covered from floor to ceiling with the large windows he could see from outside.

He has a view of a side of the station on a black background speckled with the white stars. Some people are walking along the window, eating and talking. The Polari station is the equivalent of a large city, counting over a million people on board, all working for Phallacy. Not only does it house the equivalent population of a large city, but it also functions as one, a lot of people being on board for the sole purpose of making the station run smoothly. That's why Cruiz is here. But the details and the expectations of his mission

will be revealed to him the next morning.

After walking for a good fifteen minutes, the guide turns towards him, telling him that they're getting near, they just have to go to the lower levels. He takes him to a spiraling staircase going down. He looks at the bottom of it but it goes so down that it is impossible to see the end of it.

The stairs are encased in this grey tube with occasional round windows giving you a view of the whole floor. They go down for what feels like an eternity, along the way, Cruiz asks if there isn't a more efficient way to get down, a faster mode of transportation. And indeed, there is, but they cost money and at this time of the day, they're usually taken over by the swarm of people getting on their lunch break. Finally, they reach what they call the Service Floor. Halls and corridors seem smaller here for some reason; There aren't any windows as well, but a lot more screens showing a wide array of things, mostly ads.

He recognizes himself more in the people that were going here; they're wearing on their face a fatigue and exhaustion that he can relate to. They end up in the apartment complex part of the floor, after a mazelike journey through corridors. It looks like a hotel corridor there, doors next to each other stretching on an impossibly

long gangway. They reach a door with the number 0006 on it. The guide turns to Cruiz, hands him a magnetic card, telling him that everything he will need for his first day at work on the morrow is waiting for him inside. He leaves him standing there, walking towards the other end of the seemingly never-ending hallway, towards darkness.

Finally alone, Cruiz can breathe for a moment; he uses the key to get inside his new living quarters. After a shower, he checks the fridge, a pack of vacuumed-sealed shapeless food is waiting for him. It reads “Microwavable Beef Stew”. He pours the brown mixture in one of the provided bowls and reheats it. As he eats the tasteless food over the kitchen counter, he takes a look at the map of the station. It looks like a gridded city map over five levels, with entire segments greyed out without any information, probably housing labs or other secret facilities. He lets the guide fall once again, leaves the bowl in the sink and crashes in bed. He has to be at work at seven that leaves him about six hours

of sleep, even though his body is screaming for more after the fifteen-hour trip he just took. He closes his eyes and within seconds he falls into a dreamless sleep.

An alarm clock wakes him up thirty minutes before his shift is supposed to start. Startled, he jumps out of bed right away. He doesn't want to be late for his first day, he wants to be as forgettable as possible, the most average man ever. He puts on the uniform they provided for him, a blue overall with a zipper at the front that goes all the way down. On the chest, on the right side, his name is embroidered, on the left side, the logo of the company. He grabs the badge with his card, slides the guidebook and his notebook in his pockets and is on his way. According to the manual, it takes him twenty minutes of walking to get to his workstation. He follows the custom route they have highlighted for him inside. He goes through his "building" area, walking in front of what seems to be hundreds of doors. Some people are going in the opposite direction, not even paying attention to him. Everybody he sees, however, is wearing more or less the same uniform he's wearing.

He arrives in a large empty hall where in the middle sits a grey cube with a door. He gets close to the door, waves his badge in front of the dedicated reader and the door opens. Inside is what looks like a storage room of cleaning supplies, technical materials as well as construction tools. A woman sits behind a table, paperwork spread out in front of her. He approaches her and introduces himself. She looks up and looks at him as if he were the most insignificant person in the world. She hands him a paper to sign, a liability waiver stating that if anything bad happens, he won't press charges.

He signs it without looking further, not that it matters. She stands up, and without even looking at him, tells him that his superior will be here shortly and that he can just wait here for the moment. She vanishes, leaving this place as fast as she can, her steps resonating in the distance. He looks around at the room, crammed with crap. He sits behind the table and starts taking notes in his notebook, thinking of ways to start the investigation. Now that he has seen the way the space unfolds within the station, and with the help of the map, he starts to draw out a plan.

He gets interrupted a few minutes later when a

tall man with broad shoulders and large arms comes in, with the first genuine smile he has seen since he left the planet. He extends his hand and introduces himself as Bara. His smile is drowning in his dense and dark beard and his eyes are disappearing in bushy eyebrows. Nevertheless, the man can easily be considered good looking. He is Cruiz's direct supervisor, and he will guide him through his first day, explaining to him the nature of his mission. Bara explains to him that there are hundreds of independent crews like them all over the station, each with a specific area allocated. They never cross paths, they don't even know who they are, that's the way it is on Polari Station to avoid any leak of information.

He shows him on the map the area they'll cover, which is a radius around the current room, as well as some smaller parts on the superior floor as well as the lower one. They have a very polyvalent position, from cleaning to technical upkeep, even security. Because it is only the two of them, they both have a six-hour shift every six hours; it is an intense rhythm, but it's not like there is anything else to do on the station anyway.

They have to meet up here every six hours, either to leave or start, until the end of their mission in

two months. Inside, Cruiz hopes he'll be gone by then. Bara being alone for the past few days after the early departure of his previous colleague, the workload has been accumulating so they will have a lot to do today. He starts to write down a list for them to do, writing on a sheet of paper, his large hands grabbing the tiny pen like a toothpick. Routine check of the cameras, a dispute to be resolved without the intervention of police, cleaning due in some alleyways and then maintenance on some equipment. That's how his first day starts.

He follows the chatty bear to the camera room. He couldn't have dreamt a better position than to have access to security cameras on the station, that will make his job of finding Zamil hopefully easier. Behind the doors, a small room with nothing but a chair behind a table facing a wall covered with screens. The screens are showing at least twenty different points of view. Bara sits on the chair and starts checking each camera carefully, one after the other.

He explains while checking them that most of them are hidden to most employees. They know that they're being filmed, they just don't know from where, although some cameras are open source, meaning everybody can access the feed

and see what is happening. The cameras are generally fixed, but some come from the small flying equipment that cruises above the most crowded areas. He shows Cruz one screen where the camera is moving and shows him how to move it around and zoom. The people on the camera are crystal clear, every detail of their faces, he can even read their lips. Bara keeps on checking that all of the other one's work and that nothing is obstructing the view or any abnormal activity is happening.

He then explains that they have access to every camera on the station – except for the labs – but here, the cameras only cover their perimeter of action, nothing more. The videos are stored for six months and can be checked upon request. Apparently, there is a powerful software behind the cameras that could allow them to use facial and object recognition to spot something specific, but he hasn't found the way to use it and hasn't dared to ask around.

Once done, Bara turns around in his chair with a grave air and warns him about a practice that has been happening regarding the cameras. It would appear that a handful of men are using the cameras to cruise each other. It's only a rumor, nobody has been able to provide concrete proofs but some recordings suggest that through

the open-source cameras, and even between the different custodians, some sort of intimate exchanges have been happening.

This is another important and interesting piece of data to know for him, knowing about the parallel ways that exist around the station, where he might be able to find clues as to where somebody can disappear. He will look into it later, keep an eye out, maybe ask around. They leave the camera room expletively, after this, but Cruiz's heart is full of hope. They leave straight to a commercial area where a dispute between two local merchants has been brewing for the past few days.

Bara says it as if he is some kind of recluse, however everyone they see on their way seems to know him and to nod at him. Bara seems to be a popular guy around here, which is not surprising considering the good-hearted nature he gives off. They arrive in a large hall that looks like a shopping center, with several stores selling a wide range of things. The area looks less nice than the food court two floors above, where the nicely arranged snack bars leave room to crummy stores selling cheap goods. Two sellers are having a dispute about the trash chute that keeps getting clogged and they're both blaming

the other for it and both refusing to pay the maintenance fees for it. So they asked the custodian crew to intervene and try to resolve the problem. The feud is between a small clothing store and hardware store selling spare parts.

Bara asks both the managers to talk outside about the issue and see the heart of the problem but they start screaming at each other, Bara caught in the middle, trying to get them to calm down, but the fight is escalating. The strong presence of the custodian isn't enough to calm them, quite the contrary, both the managers hide behind the large man while spewing their hate to the other.

Bara looks overwhelmed and his face gives away his annoyance. Cruiz runs to help him out, but he is being told by his superior to not interfere. He thinks for a second, a hand brushing his beard while insults fly above him, then tells the newcomer to continue the list of tasks as best as he can, and that he will come back to him before the end of the shift. And just like that, Cruiz was thrown into his job on the station. He looks at his notes and his map. An area is underlined where cleaning is necessary, and two other spots are circled where maintenance is needed. He walks back to the storage room to

get the cleaning equipment. He takes his time walking back, looking around him, paying attention to every detail and everybody he sees. On his way back, while taking another route, he gets to a spot where a piece of the wall has fallen, throwing dust and rocks around. The hallway where it happened is facing a large window, there is nothing along the way, it is a glorified corridor that had been shut down after the incident. Bara hadn't had time to tell him what happened here. A large slab of about forty kilos had fallen from the junction between the wall and the ceiling, some twenty-five meters higher. It broke in half when it fell and left a dent in the floor. Cruiz gets down to check it out from up close. He is happy to be able to touch this raw material from up close and interact with it. He grabs a smaller piece; it looks like concrete but it is cold like metal. The outside surface is very smooth while the inside is porous. It is not too heavy, but he wonders how a whole piece could fall from there. There aren't any stress marks or cracks on the slab, it simply looks like it fell. When he looks up from where it fell, he only sees a square hole at the top, nothing else. Now he gets to work, picking up the larger pieces by hand and putting them in the cart. After he is done cleaning, there aren't any traces of an ac-

cident happening except for the dent and the hole. He wonders if this was an independent accident or if he should stay alert to other pieces falling from the walls, ready to crush anything under; he will ask Bara about it. It then takes him barely over an hour to fix the small technical issue around, such as a loose wire, a hanging lamp or a noisy vent.

Once all done and unsure as to what to do next, he parks the cleaning cart back in storage, and decides to check out the camera room again, alone this time. He walks there, looks up the code he had written down earlier and closes the door behind him. Now he can start investigating while keeping an eye on Bara to know when he is coming back. He doesn't know if the station is orbiting something, if it's floating around, or if it is going somewhere, but what he sees isn't helping him to know. He keeps looking around to mostly empty meeting rooms, deserted corridors, and abandoned offices, pausing every time to see if anything relevant is hiding, without any results. He keeps going through the cameras faster and faster, most of them showing little but empty grey halls. After a while, he ends up in the wing dedicated to sports and physical activity.

The cameras show him a panorama of the field, then took him to the adjacent pools, the large gyms training grounds. Then all of a sudden, he finds himself looking inside the locker rooms, wondering of the legality of such installations. He skips past as fast as possible but can't help but notice the men changing and freezes for a second at the sight of open sex in one of the lockers. He exits quickly the camera feed, embarrassed about what he just did and takes a pause for a second. Bara is still occupied with the security.

He decides to start checking the cameras around the perimeter they supervise to get a better sense of his surroundings. He spends a couple of hours doing this, jumping from camera to camera, not finding anything really worthwhile until a stare catches his eye. He has been going through a lot of alleyways for the past thirty minutes, most of them empty, until one where a guy, standing against the wall, stares right at him, or at least at the camera.

He looks at the camera with an intense stare and a smirk folding the ends of his lips. He is wearing a blue uniform, different from the one custodian wears. Because he has his back to the wall, it is impossible to see what division he is a

part of, but his name tag says Charver. He looks back at the camera, waving this time, mouthing something. Cruiz steps back from the screens a bit, wondering if these gestures were directed at him, or if he just is a witness to something else happening. The man is standing in a hallway between two different offices, and Cruiz marks it on his map as a reminder. The man in the camera, Charver, is then joined by another gentleman. Together, they start walking.

Cruiz proceeds to follow them, camera after camera, to see where they're going. They walk together; they don't seem to talk and keep looking around each other. After five minutes, he sees them go through a small door behind a storage unit, and from there, impossible to follow them, the room isn't covered by security cameras. He is about to start and wait for them to come out, but in the corner of his eyes he sees that Bara is on the move, probably in his direction. He scribbles quickly the door the two men took on his map before leaving the room, the original layout of cameras back into place, and rushes back to the storage room.

His superior seems exhausted and crashes into a chair, putting his head in his arms. He mutters something about the worst fucking day ever. He

looks back up, staring at Cruiz standing in front of him, and tells him about the awful turn his day took with this feud. He is happy that he sent Cruiz away quickly enough that they didn't involve him in it, but he is sorry he had to figure out everything else about the day on his own. He asks him about his day, apologizing again, hoping that everything went fine. It did go fine, that's what Cruiz explains to him; everything was very straightforward and easy with the cleaning cart, and nobody bothered him. He asks about the slab that fell, wondering if it is a common issue, or if it has a reasonable explanation. Apparently, some parts of the station have been done more carefully than others. The material used everywhere needs specific conditions to be put in place, and when the job is rushed, a few months or years later, a slab falls down. There have been only isolated incidents so far, nothing on a large scale, but things might get worse as time passes.

He asks Cruiz for his badge, to credit it with his daily pay. He goes towards a machine, types in something, and gets back to him with his badge now displaying what he has earned today. He stands up heavily and together they start to walk back. They're going different directions, Bara shakes his hand and gives him a familiar

shoulder tap before wishing him a good night. On his way home, He isn't the only one going home at this hour, he is part of a slow flow going back to the apartment complex. He goes back to his room, welcoming him in absolute silence. He takes a hot shower, then crashes the bed. He stays, lying awake, thinking about his day.

He wakes up. He looks at the time, realizing that he has been sleeping for only two hours. He tries to go back to sleep but sleep evades him. He sits up in his bed, looking around the dark room. He feels like in a coffin, or a tomb. He needs air, he can't go back to sleep now. He opens a drawer and puts on the sweatpants they provided. He leaves his room and starts walking. He lets his feet take him somewhere while he lets his mind wander. At this hour, they simulate nighttime by dimming the lights, so now it feels like walking through an abandoned station. There is a certain solemnity when he walks in the empty halls with the ceilings drowned in darkness. He decides that if he is going to roam around at night, he might as well do something useful. That's when he decides that he should go back on the steps of the guy from the camera, to try and find that room he disappeared in.

He quickly finds the small alley he saw on the camera. It's empty at the moment. He posts himself right where the guy was on the feed, and looks up, looking for the lens. But with the dimmed lights and high ceiling it's impossible to see anything. He stays for a second, looking left and right, then keeps going on the guy's steps. As he gets closer, he hears chatter, at least two people talking in a loud whisper. He slows down at the corner so as to not be seen. They're walking away from him from the sound of it. He holds his breath to hear better, until their chatter disappears behind the noise of a door closing. He waits for a minute or two, then when he can't hear anything anymore, he turns the corner and walks to the door. It is the exact same door as he had seen earlier. It's a nondescript door, grey, with a physical door handle which makes it a bit old-fashioned on this station. He puts his ear to the door to try and listen to something happening inside, but he can't hear anything. He carefully opens the door. He doesn't know what to expect on the other side.

The door opens on a small staircase going down. Small lights light up the way down. He goes down slowly, and as he gets down, a smell of smoke starts to rise. Once at the bottom of the

stairs, he can hear a distinctive thumping noise. After a short walk-through tight corridors towards the noise, he finds himself in front of a black door from which the sound is coming from. No handle on this door, but a spray-painted word: knock. He takes up his courage and knocks at the large back door.

He can hear the lock on the other side being opened, and a mechanism turned. The heavy door swings towards him, opened by a bulky man wearing nothing but black. He can hear loud music and people talking. The man at the door looks Cruz up and down and asks him if he is new. He nods at the question, intimidated. The man who appears to be a bouncer then asks him who told him about the place. He freezes for a second but then remembers the name of the guy from the camera, Charver.

The bouncer looks him up and down and waves him in. Behind him there is a thick black curtain, he goes through it and enters the room. It looks and smells like the dive bars he's accustomed to, but the clientele is different. When he looks around, he sees a lot of different uniforms, people coming from different divisions, even some scientists. Apparently, they come here to chat but also to flirt. There are a lot of young

men, but not only, some women, talking among themselves, and some older men as well. That's a change from the hundreds of bleak-faced people he has seen along the corridors so far.

This is the kind of place he and Zamil would hang out at, he would have found this place. Chances are that someone here has seen him. They only serve beer, which is good enough for what looks like an illegal bar. He sips on his beer while looking at the people in the bar. The more he looks around, the more palpable the sexual tension in the air feels, like a cloud looming over everyone. People are looking around, hunting, and cruising as they talk with their friends. The music is too loud for this kind of establishment; it must be almost impossible to have a conversation.

He notices that, more like in a club than in a bar, a lot of people keep going to the bathroom and not really coming out. Maybe it would be a better ground for lightly questioning people, and the beer is starting to be processed by his metabolism anyway. He stands up and walks towards the bathroom. Two ladies, tongue-deep in each other's mouth lean against the wall in front of the door. He gets in, straight to the urinals. He relieves himself in what he thought was silence, until the soft moaning coming from

a stall brings him back to reality. But the bathroom is still quieter than he thought it would be, he has seen at least ten people disappear in here, and they're nowhere to be found. When he washes his hands, he notices in the reflection the black door behind him. Right as he turns around to check it out, someone opens it from the other side. Covered in sweat, their cheeks red, they quickly leave the room. Cruiz goes through the black door before it closes. After it shuts behind him, he understands that he just entered a darkroom. Low red light illuminates a narrow path making the black painted walls gleam like a membrane. He hesitates to keep going, knowing full well what lies further in the corridors. It smells like sweat and sex. He walks to the end of the first corridor then stops when he realizes that the corridors go sprawling in every direction, opening in small rooms along the way.

He leaves the darkroom, then the bathroom. On his way out he bumps into someone. He apologizes and smiles at the man. He recognizes him the moment his sight adjusted. He just bumped into the man from the camera, the one that led him here. He smiles at him instinctively. Charver looks at him for a second, tilts his head and

asks him if he is new around here, he hasn't seen him before. Cruiz introduces himself. The man takes a step back and thinks for a second. He points out that according to the bouncer, someone new said they got invited here with his name, could it be him? Cruiz seems a bit embarrassed but has to admit that yes, in the precipitation he had to use the name of someone he thought they'd know.

Charver understands that, but he doesn't understand where he got his name from. He has to admit that he followed him on the cameras, that's how he ended up going here. The young man doesn't seem mad or angry, he smirks, the same smirks he had on the camera feed then ask his stalker to buy him a drink to apologize. Both of them walk to the bar and sit down at the counter, Cruiz paying a round of beer for the two of them. Charver asks him how long he has been a CC Cruiser, but Cruiz doesn't understand the question.

A CC Cruiser, for Closed-Circuit Cruiser are the people using the open-source security camera feed to cruise each other, meet people, and even peep for those who like it. A whole parallel universe has been using the company's infrastructure to build their desire on it. He admits that it was an accident, that he had been

sort of bewitched by his stare looking straight at the camera.

He thinks that Charver can be a good starting point for his investigation, and it is only fair from him to share a secret after he just revealed to him the secret flirting society. So in order to make it clear why he is here now, he tells the story from the beginning. He listens intently to the story, the disappearance of Zamil here on Polari Station and the plan to find him. Cruiz gives a detailed description of his friend but he doesn't seem familiar to Charver, his name not ringing a bell, but maybe someone from an upper club might know, if he was the kind to go to these places. Because if Zamil couldn't tell him what he was doing, that means he was in one of the upper floors, working in the labs, and the upper floors have their own network of CC Cruisers and local illegal bars.

He scribbles a name and an address on a napkin for him, a guy who works in the labs but who's also a big-time cruiser, he knows everyone. Charver stands up, kisses him on the cheek, telling him he has to go, but hopes to see him around. He vanishes in the bathroom. Alone with his napkin, he thinks for a second. The night is still young, he isn't one-bit tired, maybe he will go on an excursion before his shift starts.

He still has eight hours, plenty of time to investigate.

He swings by his room to get his map and his notebook. He only has a name, but he can probably find the guy and where he is if he uses and hacks the cameras a little bit in the camera room. Once in the camera room, Cruiz enters the name written on the napkin into the computer and waits. He holds his breath, expecting an alarm, or the cameras to shut down, but after a few seconds, a man appears on the central monitor. He is crouching in an alley. The coordinates locate him two floors up, almost right above him. He scribbles his position on his map and leaves the room. He starts walking fast towards the large elevators.

He has to get up there before the man vanishes. He gets to the elevator without seeing anyone. A small display above the door relays a message saying that the elevators are closed at night except in case of emergency. He looks around for an emergency button or something, but nothing. He will have to take the long, never-ending stairs. He feels defeated but doesn't lose hope. He goes to the staircase, looks up but can't even see the top.

There are more people coming and going on this floor, small groups of people chatting, laughing. He straightens his clothes and his hair then goes towards the point on his map. He doesn't know where people are going, or where they come from, but it looks like the upper floors benefit from a richer nightlife than the bottom ones. He's only a few halls away from his destination when a loud growling noise echoes around him, as if two large chunks of metal were rubbed against each other. He looks around him but can't see anything. Suddenly, some people start to run away from where he is going, but the noise stops.

He keeps walking, close to his destination, when this time, loud crushing noises come from above him, large chunks of walls falling around. He tries to run when the floor beneath his feet cracks and darkness swallows him.

Black. He can't see anything. His neck hurts really bad and he can feel something hot running down his left arm. He is confused; he remembered the floor opening under his feet, falling a few meters and getting hit in the head by rocks falling from above. He can see himself

sliding in a long conduit the size of an air vent, dust making the air unbreathable, until the vent spat at him, dropping what felt forever before hitting the ground. He saw stars then nothing. He must have been out for a moment.

He stands up with difficulty, his body hurting all over now. He feels a wall behind him, leaning against it to stand up straight. He waits a second for his sight to adapt, but he cannot see anything, impossible to tell how big the place he fell into is. He screams with a broken voice, echoing in what sounds like a big, empty room. But after a few minutes, his eyes pick up a small glimmer in the distance, a white dot, no bigger than a star in the sky. He blinks several times, making sure that his eyes weren't damaged in the fall, and when it appears that the small dot is real, he starts to walk towards it. His senses are all thrown off, it could be a dot ten meters away from him or a light two kilometers away, he couldn't tell.

As he walks towards the light, he regains hope, thinking that he must have fallen a floor below in an empty warehouse. AS he walks, the light appears to be an opening in the wall. The doorway now just a few steps ahead, a wave of relief washes over him, almost running towards it. The bright white light blinds him, and as he

goes through the gate, he falls again. This time, his fall is cushioned by the luscious green leaves of a fern bush, firmly planted in a rich, earthy soil. His confusion is total; he didn't know that there were real plants and dirt on board of the station. He stands up again, feeling his body for new pain, and looks up from where he fell. There is a hole in the wall about six meters above him. When he looks around him, he sees a vast stretch of greenery, spanning distances that seem impossible in a station the size of the Polari Station. The room is so big that he can feel a breeze of air carrying the smell of forests and fields. The white light comes from the ceiling emitting a diffuse white light, like an overcast sun. Large grey walls like the ones around the station encompass the greenery like fortified walls.

He starts walking straight ahead. The air is very humid, he is getting a little bit hot as he walks, sweat starting to pour down his back. He is through a clearing of ferns towards a dense forest. The plants around him are varied, almost incompatible. He notices some bugs flying away from him as he bothers them in their living.

Right before he reaches the forest, a small stream of water cuts his way. He lunges at it, dipping his head in it, drinking the cold water

straight from the stream. He washes his face and his wound. He is intensely focused and doesn't realize that someone is approaching him. He jumps in surprise, letting out a small scream when he sees the young woman wearing a short and a bra look at him incredulously. She holds her hands up in surprise and tells him that she won't harm him and she is going to help him. She approaches him, and with her soft black hands help him up. She introduces herself as Lazarus and is taking him back to their settlement.

She asks for his name, and as he starts to ask questions, she stops him, telling him that the time for questions is later because there is going to be much to be explained. He lets himself be guided, enjoying the walk in the woods. It is a short but quite difficult walk in the uneven terrain, but they eventually reach the settlement. It is like a small village built inside the forest with wooden contraption carefully built around the trees, linking them together. She brings him inside one, lays him on a straw bed and he passes out before being able to thank her.

He wakes up in the dark, he could think that he is back to where he had fallen and that the forest and the ferns were a dream, but thankfully the straw mattress below him is concrete evidence

that he did not imagine everything. It's warm inside, and it smells like bark. Someone sleeps in the chair next to the bed, probably looking over him while he is resting. His arm is bandaged and his face has been cleaned. He tries to sit up, a wave of dizziness submerging him.

The person that was sleeping next to him reaches out to help him up. He takes the powerful arm gladly, and he realizes who is helping him, smelling a familiar smell before seeing the face of his benefactor. Zamil smiles at him when he sees his stunned face. They share a long hug. Cruiz has a hard time believing that he is real, really here, that he found him, somehow. But he is, they are reunited at last. But Cruiz is confused. He doesn't understand where they are, and how they got here, how he got here; is this a research facility, is this what happens in the labs, are their crops on board of the station. Zamil sits back down in the chair and takes a long breath.

He asks Cruiz if he knows how the station has been built and how it works. He talks while holding his hand. He asks if he has noticed how bizarre the layout of the ship is, how some empty rooms lead to more empty rooms, impossibly tall, long corridors that lead nowhere and buildings standing inside halls. If it looks like the

layout hasn't been thought-through it is because it hasn't. There is no architect behind it, not a human one anyway. A computer has generated and keeps generating the configuration of the station. Phallacy doesn't care or perhaps doesn't even know.

That's why pieces fall apart, and some things stop working; new rooms are being generated at random, old ones fall apart. It's in this context that a small group of employees used this fault to their advantage; they hacked the station, created this place between two floors, in the interstices of the Polari Station. This place doesn't really exist; it's a pure haven. The computer doesn't take it into account, that's why trash and debris fall here, sometimes people, and they become part of this life-scale terrarium. But it often feels like the people who fall here don't fall here by mistake, something about them guided them here, illustrated by Cruiz's arrival. Cruiz looks incredulous, taking time to process the story that he just heard. What about him, why didn't he send out for help, why didn't he reach out to his closest friend.

Because, Zamil answers, he didn't need a knight in shining armor to come and save him. He's sorry he didn't send a message, not that it is

really possible anyway, but he simply found his place, his people. Life here is simple. When you take care of the soil beneath your feet and learn how to use the infinite trash coming from above, you're not surviving anymore, you're simply living. Silence lands between them. Stunned, Cruiz doesn't know what to say. He feels stupid and useless. He lies back down on the bed, still holding Zamil's hand, and lets sleep take over him. When he wakes up a few hours later, he is alone in the cabin. Light filters through the walls and the ceiling. He feels rested but his body aches.

He goes outside, the light blinding him for a second. The light breeze feels wonderful on his face. Outside, people are awake, moving around the trees, busy with daily tasks. He stays in the door frame, observing the busy camp. Everybody is so beautiful, perhaps this is the perfect, harmonious, utopic picture the company should put in their commercials. He feels almost out of place, wondering his place in all of this, the pseudo-savior, the over inflated ego. He is deep in his thoughts when Zamil joins him, putting his back against the wall next to him. He asks him what he thinks of it all, does he want to join.